

SHABBOS, DUAL FOUNDATION OF OUR FAITH

This is a more comprehensive version of the Essay "The Mystery of the "Second Luchos" which is appended to Sidra of the Week: יתרו

In the Sidra ואתחנן is described the Luchos, the Two Tablets, with the words of the Decalogue engraved on them. The Luchos are also described in Sidra יתרו, but the words on the Luchos as reported in Sidra יתרו are quite different. One of the major differences can be seen in the two versions of the commandment concerning Shabbos.

First, here is the version that is given in Sidra יתרו:

Remember the Shabbos Day to keep it holy. Six days shall you labour and do all your work. But the seventh day is Shabbos to G-d your Lord. You shall not do any kind of Melochoh, neither you, nor your son, nor your daughter, nor your manservant nor your maidservant, nor your animals, nor the stranger that is within your city gates. For in six days G-d made the heavens and the earth and the sea and all that it is in them and He rested on the seventh day. Therefore G-d blessed the Shabbos Day and He made it holy.

It is noteworthy that the Torah exhorts us to work during the week: "Six days shall you labour..." There is nothing lowly in doing honest work, as the occupations of many of the Sages of the Gemorroh, the Tano'im and Amoro'im, testify.

Let us examine the Torah's work ethic further for it will help us to better understand the Mitzvah of Shabbos.

Regarding this Possuk, "Six days shall you labour and do all your work" there are some who might argue that this is not so much a command to work but more an acceptance of the fact that Man *has* to work. After all, they might well point out, G-d decreed upon Adam and all his descendants, "By the sweat of your brow shall you eat bread," from which it appears that work is not an ideal but rather a sad imposition.

But they would be mistaken. They are wrong because, "By the sweat of your brow shall you eat bread" was never meant as a degradation of Man, nor of work. On the contrary, the Gemorroh tells us that "Great is work for it ennobles those that do it!" (Tractate Nedorrim, 49b) When Adam was told that he was like the animals in that he, too, must eat to survive, he wept. "Am I and my donkey to eat from the same feedbag?" Our Chachommim tell us that he was reconciled to his physicality only when he was told that he will work and that his was a sacred task, for through his work and his toil he was to bring the world under human control in the service of G-d.

This message was reinforced by G-d implanting in the human being a kind of spiritual discontent, a feeling of being unfulfilled, that does not allow him to fully enjoy things for which he has not worked, giving rise to the unusual phenomenon of "the unhappy rich." "For Man is born to toil" (Iyyov, 5 : 7) and he cannot be truly happy when he eats the unearned "bread of shame." Even to enjoy his physical world, Man is restless and out of sorts until he has *earned* his enjoyment.

"By the sweat of your brow shall you eat bread" is usually understood as a decree and an imposition because it does imply that there will be toil and struggle and frustration simply to provide the essentials of life, without anything spiritual in this quest. Yet if his physical labour is intended by him as serving G-d and it is done in accordance with His will, then Man's work is

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elevated and given purpose. Man's physical effort is then indeed dignified and invested with meaning by G-d's command, "Six days shall you labour and do all your work" for mundane labour has become Divine service.

How many centuries, millennia even, has it taken the world to grasp this fundamental truth of the dignity of work! And how far removed from the Torah ideal is the Greek and Roman idea of labour as degrading, with the resultant lack of rights of the labourer! Down to the present-day, the lowly status of the working man in some parts of the world is directly attributable to the disdainful attitude towards work. How much social unrest and misery, how many wars and revolutions, how much bloodshed, could mankind have spared itself had the Biblical ideal of the dignity of labour been made from the very beginning the basis of the social order!

Yet work is not all. Work can make man free, but one can also become a slave to work. Man's creativity and work gives him the possibility to rule the world. But there must be a limit to his labours for otherwise man's ambition to control and master can degenerate into endless drudgery.

The stars and the planets, the whole universe of nature that G-d created, having once started on their eternal rounds, go on blindly, ceaselessly, driven by G-d's laws of nature of cause and effect. Man, too, is driven to work. But Man is not like the rest of creation. He is free for he can choose to desist from working like the animal works and instead he can invest his life of work with spirituality and G-dliness.

After His work of creation, G-d Himself controlled and limited His creation and stopped creating anything more. And in the same way, by our ceasing from work every Shabbos in the manner prescribed by the Torah, we too limit and control our ambition to master the world, so as to devote some time in our lives that is dedicated to G-d. Man becomes, in the words of our Chachommim, "דומה ליוצרו" — "similar to His Creator," for by choosing to affirm in this manner that G-d is the Creator, Man too shows himself to be work's master, not its slave. By using his freedom in this way to bring spirituality into his world of work, to testify that G-d is the Creator of the Universe and its Master, the Jew thus becomes, in the words of our Chachommim, a "שותף במעשה בראשית" — "associated with G-d in the work of Creation."

Man's great powers over the world of nature, which allow him to control and master it, to harness its energies and mould it and adapt it to his will, these very powers make it dangerously easy to see himself as the master of the world, responsible to no-one higher than himself. The Shabbos is the weekly reminder that G-d Almighty is the Creator of the world and that Man must use all his powers in His service, to live his life according to the Divine Will. Comes the weekly Shabbos, and we are stopped from exercising our characteristic human powers of producing and creating and mastering the material world and by this very inactivity we pay homage to G-d and acknowledge Him as our Creator and Master.

That is why the commandment of the Shabbos follows on from the first three commandments of the Decalogue. The first is the commandment to acknowledge G-d. The second is to assert that there is no power other than He. The third commands us to respect and revere G-d and the fourth, the commandment of Shabbos, brings G-d into the world of human activity and ambition.

In Sidra יתרו, the Torah gives the reason why we are to keep Shabbos: It is our testimony that in six days G-d created the heavens and the earth and all that is in them and that He rested on Shabbos from creating anything more. At the same time, the Shabbos is also G-d's weekly exhortation to us: "I have placed you in this world of Mine. Everything I have created is for you. See to it that you take good care of My world, that you do not corrupt it or destroy it."

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Thus, at the same time as proclaiming Man's freedom from the drudgery of ceaseless work, this very not doing "any manner of Melochoh" also declares Man's subservience to G-d Almighty and is his testimony of G-d as the Creator of heaven and earth.

In the Luchos of this week's Sidra of ואתחנן, however, there are noticeable differences:

Guard the Shabbos day to keep it holy as G-d your Lord has commanded you. Six days shall you labour and do all your work. But the seventh day is Shabbos to G-d your Lord. You shall not do any kind of Melochoh neither you, nor your son, nor your daughter, nor your manservant, nor your maidservant, nor your ox, nor your ass, nor any of your animals, nor your stranger that is within your gates — so that your manservant and your maidservant may rest just as you rest. And you shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt and G-d your Lord brought you out from there with a strong hand and an outstretched arm. For that reason, G-d your Lord commands you to keep the Shabbos day.

But the fundamental reason for Shabbos that is given in Sidra יתרו — that is, that G-d created the heavens and earth in six days and rested on the seventh day — is not given here at all! What is said, is that our manservant and maidservant shall rest the same as we do and that we shall remember that we were slaves in Egypt and that G-d took us out from there. But G-d as Creator is not even mentioned! Why is this?

Perhaps we can explain it like this: First of all, it must be understood that in reality there is no such thing as "the First Luchos" and "the Second Luchos" as if there were two versions. (Although there are some commentaries who speak in such terms, what they mean is rather that the two *accounts* given of the Luchos are to teach us different things.) As a result of our making the Golden Calf, Mosheh our Teacher smashed the Luchos. After much prayer and repentance, G-d told Mosheh to hew out another two tablets of stone and יכתבתי על הלוחות את הדברים "I will inscribe these new tablets with the very same words that were on the first Luchos that you smashed." So clearly the words in both sets of Luchos were the same. It turns out that the wording given in Sidra ואתחנן is not the report of the actual words on the second Luchos. Rather it is the narrative of Mosheh our Teacher concerning the Luchos, recalling for us in general terms what was on the Luchos and incorporating in his narrative also his explanations of those Luchos (as can be seen from the phrase באשר צוה ה' א-לדיך and suchlike).

Now, it is the gift of a good teacher to anticipate the questions of his pupils and to address them even before they raise them. Mosheh our Teacher was the greatest teacher we ever had and as our teacher, he anticipates the question that the Mitzvah of Shabbos might raise in the mind of some people and he addresses that question. As follows:

A person might say to himself or herself: Is it really possible that through observing the Shabbos I testify that HaShem is the Creator of the Universe? But how can it be that little me, by my not switching on a light on Shabbos, by my desisting from watering my plants on Shabbos, should be considered as a witness to HaShem as the Creator? He is so unspeakably powerful, so incredibly great, so remote from me — aren't my actions or inactions so insignificant? It is hard to believe that G-d Almighty should be concerned with me at all, that He should have ever commanded that I am to observe and guard the Shabbos as my testimony to His being the Creator of all! Maybe the Shabbos is for great and holy people, but me? He is so great and I am so small — surely my observing the Shabbos is a presumptuous futility!

Says Mosheh our Teacher: Wrong! HaShem is indeed great, unspeakably great, yes. And with all that, He is indeed interested in all His creatures and especially in each of us, His Chosen

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People. See! We were a people enslaved in Egypt, powerless and without any rational hope of redemption from there by our own efforts. But then HaShem, the Creator of All and the Father of Mankind, looked down from On High and He Himself took us out from Egypt, the House of Slavery, to be His People, as He had promised our forefathers, Avrohom, Yitzchok and Yaakov. And as His People, it is our sacred duty to bear testimony to HaShem not only as the Creator of the World but also as the G-d of all Mankind, Who wishes His creatures to conduct themselves according to His wishes. This, that HaShem is the G-d and Father of all Mankind Who oversees everything, is the lesson and the testimony of Shabbos just as much as the Shabbos is our testimony of HaShem the Creator.

That G-d is the Creator of everything is obvious and hardly needs restating by Mosheh here in Sidra וַתִּתֵּן. But what Mosheh means to stress in his review of the event of Mattan Torah is that not only are we ourselves to guard and observe the Shabbos but we are to keep the Shabbos together with our manservant and maidservant, “so that they shall rest just as you do.” Remember the less fortunate, says Mosheh. Don’t be all holy and spiritual at the expense of others, or even without including others. Be considerate to those who are your subordinates, too. Remember, you were slaves in Egypt, and therefore G-d commands you to observe the Shabbos day together with your manservant and maidservant. For great as He is, even as He is Almighty G-d, the Creator of heaven and earth, He is involved with all His human creatures. And He is the Lord and Judge and rewards each according to how he or she obeys His commands.

Incidentally, it is interesting to see here how the Torah bids us to be kind and considerate to our manservants and maidservants. Remember that this law was commanded to us over thirty-three centuries ago, when the concept of civil rights — indeed, even the idea of human rights at all — hardly existed anywhere in the non-Jewish world. Yet the Torah — more than three thousand years ago — commands that we are to give rest and respite to our non-Jewish manservant and maidservant “so that they shall rest *just as you do*.”

The master like the servant, the servant like the master — and both under the All-Seeing Eye of G-d! — for the blessings of the Shabbos extend to anyone who is part of the Jewish People. On Shabbos, everybody, the master and the servant, are as equals, both are subservient to G-d, the Father of all Mankind. On Shabbos, we are generally not allowed to order anyone to do anything that we may not do ourselves. Shabbos is for “the stranger within the gates” too, and indeed we are bidden that even the animal is not to be worked by us on G-d’s Shabbos Day.

“So that your manservant and maidservant shall rest *just as you do*.” Imagine! They are to sit at our table, they are to enjoy the relaxation of Shabbos together with us. For remember, says Mosheh our Teacher, how you were slaves in Egypt. Remember how you appreciated every kindness that was done to you. Your slavery in Egypt, says Mosheh, was to train you to have feeling for others, to empathise with the less fortunate and this is your duty as the People of G-d: to show consideration and kindness to others. This, too, is no less a part of the Shabbos, says Mosheh our Teacher.

Shabbos is thus the dual foundation of our faith. Firstly, it is the weekly reminder that G-d is the Creator of All. And secondly it is our affirmation that G-d is the Father of all Mankind, Who protests against slavery and oppression of the human spirit — and Who sometimes will even interfere in human affairs to protect the dignity of Man — for He desires Man’s spiritual advancement as much as the material progress of Mankind. No wonder that tyrants of all times have tried to stop us from celebrating G-d’s holy Shabbos. But they will never succeed. For despite everything, “אִתּוֹ הִיא לְעוֹלָם” — the Shabbos will always be the special bond between G-d and us, His holy People.